College of Social and Behavioral Sciences
Master of Arts in Clinical Mental Health Counseling
COUN 5173 Crisis Counseling and Abuse
Spring 2026

Instructor:
Esther McCartney, Ph. D., LMHC
E-mail: esther.mccartney@northwestu.edu,

Office Hours:
By appointment only.

Class Schedule: Thursdays 6pm-10pm

Thursday, Jan 8
Thursday, Feb 5
Friday, Feb 13 No meeting- Psychological 1st aid training and Suicidal Assessment Training
Thursday, Feb 26
Thursday, March 5
Thursday, March 19
Thursday, April 2
Thursday, April 9

Communications policy
My preferred method of communication is email. Please allow 24-48 business hours for me to respond to your emails. I will respond to emails during the hours of 9AM-5PM Monday-Friday.

Instructor policy on cell phones, laptops, and other electronic devices
During class sessions there is a professional expectation that electronic devices are not to be used other than to access the classroom and participate in class activities. Checking social media, searching the internet, and text messaging during class sessions, tends to result in students missing course information. Ultimately this leads to poor performance and possible point deductions.

Theme Verse:
The Lord is close to the brokenhearted and saves those who are crushed in spirit.
Psalm 24: 18 (NIV)
Required text:

- Hunsinger, D. van D. (2015). Bearing the Unbearable: Trauma, Gospel, and Pastoral Care. Eerdmans Publishing. ISBN 978-0-8028-7103-9
- Jackson-Cherry, L. R., & Erford, B. T. (2024). Crisis assessment, intervention, and prevention (4th ed.). Pearson

Recommended Articles:

Albaek, A. U., Kinn, L. G., & Milde, A. M. (2018). Walking Children Through a Minefield: How Professionals Experience Exploring Adverse Childhood Experiences. *Qualitative Health Research*, *28*(2), 231–244. https://doi.org/10.1177/1049732317734828

Asselt, K. W. V., Soli, L. L., & Berry, E. L. (2016). Crisis fearlessness: A call for trauma competencies in counselor education. *The Journal of Individual Psychology, 72*(3), 200-213. https://doi.org/10.1353/jip.2016.0017

Benjet, et al. (2016). The epidemiology of traumatic event exposure worldwide: Results from the world mental health survey consortium. *Psychological Medicine*, *46*(2), 327-343. http://dx.doi.org.ezproxy.regent.edu/10.1017/S0033291715001981

Branson, D. C. (2019). Vicarious trauma, themes in research, and terminology: A review of literature. *Traumatology*, *25*(1), 2–10. https://doi.org/10.1037/trm0000161

Cook, J. M., Newman, E., & The New Haven Trauma Competency Group (2014). A consensus statement on trauma mental health: The New Haven Competency Conference process and major findings. *Psychological Trauma: Theory, Research, Practice, and Policy*, *6*(4), 300-307. https://doi.org/10.1037/a0036747

Courtois, C. & Ford, J. (2016). *Treatment of complex trauma: A sequenced, relationship-based approach.* Guilford Press.

Dalsania, A. K., Fastiggi, M. J., Kahlam, A., Shah, R., Patel, K., Shiau, S., Slawa, R., & Dalla Piazza, M. (2022). The relationship between social determinants of health and racial disparities in COVID-19 mortality. *Journal of Racial and Ethnic Health Disparities, 9*(1), 288-295. https://doi.org/10.1007/s40615-020-00952-y

Felitti V. J., Anda R.F., Nordenberg D., Williamson D.F., Spitz A.M., Edwards V., Koss M.P., Marks J.S. (1998). Relationship of childhood abuse and household dysfunction to many of the leading causes of death in adults. The adverse childhood experiences (ACE) study. *American Journal of Preventative Medicine. 14*(4), 245-58. https://doi: 10.1016/s0749-3797(98)00017-8.

Forbes, D., Bisson, J. I., Monson, C. M., Berliner, L. (2020), *Effective treatments for PTSD: Practice guidelines from the International Society for Traumatic Stress Studies*. Guilford Press.

Gentry, J. E., Baranowsky, A. B., & Rhoton, R. (2017). Trauma competency: An active ingredients approach to treating posttraumatic stress disorder. *Journal of Counseling and Development, 95(*3), 279-287. doi:10.1002/jcad.12142

Henning, J. A., Brand, B., & Courtois, C. A. (2021). Graduate training and certification in trauma treatment for clinical practitioners. *Training and Education in Professional Psychology*. https://doi.org/10.1037/tep0000326

Herman, J. L. (1997). *Trauma and recovery*. Basic Books.

Kezelman, C., & Stavropoulos, P. (2019). *Practice guidelines for clinical treatment of complex trauma.* Blue Knot Foundation. https://www.blueknot.org.au/resources/Publications/Practice-Guidelines

Kumar, S. A., Brand, B. L., & Courtois, C. A. (2019). The need for trauma training: Clinicians' reactions to training on complex trauma. *Psychological Trauma: Theory, Research, Practice, and Policy*, https://doi.org/10.1037/tra0000515

Lanier, B. A., & Carney, J. S. (2019). Practicing counselors, vicarious trauma, and subthreshold PTSD: Implications for counselor educators. *The Professional Counselor*, *9*(4), 334-346. https://tpcjournal.nbcc.org/practicing-counselors-vicarious-trauma-and-subthreshold-ptsd-implications-for-counselor-educators/

Liddel, B. J., & Jobson, L. (2016). The impact of cultural differences in self-representation on the neural substrates of posttraumatic stress disorder. *European Journal of Psychotraumatology, 7*(1), 1–13. https://doi.org/10.3402/ejpt.v7.30464

Pau, K., Ahmad, A., & Tang, HY. (2020) Crisis, disaster, and trauma counseling: Implications for the counseling profession. *Journal of Critical Reviews*, *7*(8), 736-739. https://www.jcreview.com/admin/Uploads/Files/61ba4ef50534a7.67923217.pdf

Quitangon, G. (2019). Vicarious trauma in clinicians: Fostering resilience and preventing burnout. *Psychiatric Times*, *36*(7), 18–19. https://www.psychiatrictimes.com/view/vicarious-trauma-clinicians-fostering-resilience-and-preventing-burnout

Stamm BH. The ProQOL Manual: *The Professional Quality of Life Scale: Compassion satisfaction, burnout & compassion fatigue/secondary trauma scales*. Sidran Press. https://doi.org/10.1037/tra0000263

Struck, S., Stewart-Tufescu, A., Asmundson, A. J., Asmundson, G. G., & Afifi, T. O. (2021). Adverse childhood experiences (ACEs) research: A bibliometric analysis of publication trends over the first 20 years. *Child Abuse & Neglect*, *112*, 104895–104895. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.chiabu.2020.104895

Tarshis, S., & Baird, S. L. (2019). Addressing the indirect trauma of social work students in intimate partner violence (IPV) field placements: A framework for supervision. *Clinical Social Work Journal, 47*(1), 90-102. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10615-018-0678-1

Tarvydas, V. M., Levers, L. L., & Teahen, P. R. (2017). Ethical guidelines for mass trauma and complex humanitarian emergencies. *Journal of Counseling & Development, 95*(3), 260-268. https://doi.org/10.1002/jcad.12140

Webber, J. M., Kitzinger, R., Runte, J. K., Smith, C. M., & Mascari, J. B. (2017). Traumatology trends: A content analysis of three counseling journals from 1994 to 2014. *Journal of Counseling and Development, 95*(3), 249-259. https://doi.org/10.1002/jcad.12139

Course Description:

Students will learn about crisis theory and intervention, multidisciplinary responses to crises, and biopsychosocial impacts of trauma on individuals, families, and communities. Additionally, students will gain an overview of issues surrounding child, partner, and elder abuse. Special attention is given to assessment, and the legal and ethical responsibilities of a mandated reporter.

Course Objectives:

- Apply theories of crisis and abuse intervention.
- Evaluate multicultural issues including bi-psycho-social influences in crisis and abuse intervention.
- Assess crisis and abuse situations for ethical and legal responsibilities.

2024 CACREP Standards

3.A.3	counselors' roles, responsibilities, and relationships as members of specialized practice and interprofessional teams, including (a) collaboration and consultation, (b) community outreach, and (c) emergency response management
3.B.11	the role of religion and spirituality in clients' and counselors' psychological functioning
3.C.7	models of resilience, optimal development, and wellness in individuals and families across the lifespan
3.C.12	the influence of mental and physical health conditions on coping, resilience, and overall wellness for individuals and families across the lifespan
3.C.13	effects of crises, disasters, stress, grief, and trauma across the lifespan
3.E.19	suicide prevention and response models and strategies
3.E.20	crisis intervention, trauma-informed, community-based, and disaster mental health strategies
3.G.13	procedures for assessing and responding to risk of aggression or danger to others, self-inflicted harm, and suicide
3.G.14	procedures for assessing clients' experience of trauma
3.G.16	procedures to identify client characteristics, protective factors, risk factors, and warning signs of mental health and behavioral disorders

Objectives	*Readings*	*Case Conceptualization*	*Psychological First Aid Course and Certificate*	*Institutional Disaster Presentation*	*Midterm Exam*	*Assessment and Intervention with Suicidal Clients Training and Reflection*	*Reflections*
3.A.3	X			X			
3.B.11	X						X
3.C.7	X	X	X				X
3.C.12	X	X					
3.C.13	X			X			
3.E.19	X					X	
3.E.20	X		X	X		X	
3.G.13	X	X				X	
3.G.14	X	X					
3.G.16	X	X	X	X		X	

Assignments	KPI 1	KPI 2	KPI 3	KPI 4	KPI 5	KPI 6	KPI 7	KPI 8	KPI 9
Case Study: Crisis Assessment and Intervention				X					

Academic Honesty:
Northwest University expects honesty from students in all areas, including their academic lives. Academic dishonesty is a serious violation of university standards and may result in the students' receiving an "F" on the assignment, receiving an "F" for the course, or being dismissed from the University. Instances of academic dishonesty are coordinated through the respective graduate program office and typically reported to the Provost's Office.
Academic dishonesty includes cheating on assignments or examinations, submitting the same (or essentially the same) paper in more than one course without prior consent of the current assigning professor(s), sabotaging another student's work, and plagiarizing. Plagiarism is "using someone else's ideas or phrasing and representing those ideas or phrasing as our own, either on purpose or through carelessness" (MLA). Any student disciplined by a faculty member for alleged academic dishonesty has the right to appeal the disciplinary action. The student should initiate his/her appeal according to procedures outlined in the Northwest University Student Academic Appeals Policy, which is available in the provost Office.

Attendance Policy:
Class attendance is extremely important for student learning and achievement of specified course outcomes, and, in turn, the program aims. Hence, attendance at all class sessions is expected. At minimum, students absent for a class session will need to make up any missed assignments or exercises, watch the class recording, and complete the expected readings. Students may not miss more than one class. Additional policies and consequences are at the discretion of the individual professor of the course. More than one missed class session will result in failure of the course and require a retake to continue in the program. In this circumstance, the student is encouraged to withdraw from the course and retake the class when it is offered again. In the event of unusual circumstances (e.g., extended illness, emergency), a student may appeal the automatic course failure. A proposal outlining a plan for satisfactory course completion will be required, composed by the professor, and agreed to by the student. In addition, the plan will require approval by the program director and Dean.

Disability Accommodations and Procedures:
For students with learning differences and/or physical disabilities, as defined by the ADA and Section 504 of the Rehabilitation Act, Northwest University takes an individual and holistic approach to providing accommodations. Accommodations are developed and approved on an individual basis by the Student Development Office, not the CMHC program or individual faculty members. Students needing accommodations for a diagnosed disability should follow the procedures provided on the Student Development Office's website for disability accommodations.

Communication Policy:
Timely communication between the professor and students is important to the program's overall functioning. Therefore, both students and faculty should respond to email or phone messages within two business days. If the professor is out-of-office, an automatic reply message (on email) or voicemail recording (phone) provides the date of his/her return, as well as an in-office contact for urgent requests.

Grading Policy:
Grading is conducted on the Discovery Grade Book page of the course. Students are expected to monitor their progress accordingly. Assignments and tests will generally be graded within two weeks. Final papers and projects may take up to three weeks. The professor will let you know if there are exceptional circumstances preventing a timely return of grades. If you have concerns about grading timing, please check with the professor, program coordinator, or program chair.

Late Work Policy:
It is the student's responsibility to meet all deadlines for class assignments. Late assignments will be accepted up until one week after the due date with a 10% reduction. **After that, late assignments will not be accepted without prior approval.** Grading is conducted on the Discovery grade book page of the course. Students are expected to monitor their progress. It is your responsibility to communicate with the professor promptly about late work and absences.

APA Style and Formatting

All assignments should be turned in using the current edition of the APA style manual. APA formatting includes a title page, headers, abstract, introduction, discussion, summary, references. Please review the APA style guide for information on how to correctly format your papers. In addition, assignments should be written in APA style with a focus on clarity, conciseness, and cohesion. Unless noted as a reflection, students should use academic language and review assignments for grammatical errors.

Mechanics of the Course:
A) Class Sessions

Class sessions will be used for a variety of purposes including:
Lecture
Class and group discussion
Writing
Presentations

B) Exams: Midterm Exam
The course will have one exam in class 3. The content of the exam will cover materials from chapter 1-4, and 6 of the Jackson-Cherry & Erford text. It will be a 60-question exam and students will have 90 minutes to complete. It is a closed book exam.

C) Response, Research, or Written Assignments:

Assignment 1- Case Study: Crisis Assessment and Intervention

This is a Key Assessment

Applying knowledge and information from your reading and the assessment and intervention with suicidal clients videos (Psychotherapy.net, 2008) we will watch: *The wounds we cannot see* featuring Nancy Ross in class and develop a case study, imagining Nancy Ross as your client.
Due in Class 5

- Summary of the client's history (including family history, academic/occupational history, medical information, developmental/social history, history of trauma)
- Any current crisis issues, including suicide risk factors, and your plan to address them
- Ethical and legal considerations including mandated reporting
- Multi-cultural and spiritual considerations
- Client strengths
- Evidence for diagnostic considerations
- Basic Treatment plan: identify at least 2 problems, 2 Client goal(s) with at least 2 objectives for each goal, and your intervention and plan for working with Nancy. These should be written in SMART (Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, Timely) format. Use the treatment plan layout for this page.
- Identify resources and referrals you would offer this client
- Countertransference reactions may emerge for you as you consider working with this client
- Questions you have, to address in supervision

Please answer the above items in paragraph form. No bullet points, except on the treatment plan, please use this assignment to pull in learning from other classes in your studies and use APA formatting. Use precise language to clearly demonstrate your learning and ability to identify crisis intervention techniques and understanding with Nancy.

Instructions:

- Length is approximately 4-6 pages). This does not include the Student Title Page or Reference Page.
- APA 7 Format, 1-inch margins, 12-point Times New Roman font, double spaced, student title page and reference pages.

*Please note: This assignment is a key performance indicator for your proficiency in Counseling Theories, Skills, and Helping Relationships at this point in the program. Your knowledge of counseling skills, case conceptualization, suicide prevention, and treatment planning into counseling practice, both in-person and technology assisted settings, for those in crisis will be assessed.

Assignment 2: Assessment and Intervention with Suicidal Clients Training: Due in Class 2

This assignment aims to deepen your understanding of assessment and intervention strategies with suicidal clients through guided training videos and a corresponding manual.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. **Watch Training Videos:** You are required to watch the following **three** training videos provided by *Psychotherapy.net* on the topic of **Assessment and Intervention with Suicidal Clients (Parts 1,2, and 3)**. Ensure you pay close attention to the techniques, strategies, and case examples presented in the videos.

2. **Reflection:** This reflection assignment is designed to help you critically engage with and synthesize the knowledge gained from the training videos and manual on **Assessment and Intervention with Suicidal Clients**. Through this reflection, you will connect the course material with your personal insights, professional development, and future practice.

   Possible Reflection Prompts:

   - **Key points:** What important points did you learn in watching John Sommers-Flanagan work with various suicidal clients? What stands out most to you about how he worked with his clients? Did you get a solid sense of the concepts and techniques, and the flow of the interventions in the demonstrated cases? Why or why not?
   - **What I found most helpful:** As a counselor/therapist, what was most beneficial to you about the ideas and/or techniques presented? What specific tips or perspectives did you find helpful and might you use in your own clinical work? What about the way he worked challenged you to think about something in a new way?
   - **What does not make sense:** Which of his ideas or interventions did not make sense to you? Did anything push your buttons or bring about a sense of discomfort or resistance in you, or just not fit with your own style of working?
   - **Individualizing your Approach:** What might you do differently from Sommers-Flanagan when assessing or treating a suicidal client? Be specific about what different models, interventions or techniques you might apply.
   - **Acknowledging Cultural Differences:** How did the counselor differ his approach with each client? How did he take into account cultural, ethnic, gender, or spiritual differences of the clients that he worked with?
   - **Other questions/reactions:** What questions or reactions did you have as you viewed the video? Other comments, thoughts, or feelings?

3. **Guidelines**: Be brief and concise. Do NOT provide a full synopsis of the video. This is meant to be a brief reaction paper that you write soon after watching the video—we want your ideas and reactions. Your reflection should be **2-3 pages** in length, double-spaced, using APA 7th edition formatting. This includes: Title page (required but not counted in the page count), proper headings to organize your thoughts, and References page (if you cite additional sources). **Format:** Use 12-point Times New Roman font, include a title page, page numbers, and properly formatted in-text citations (if applicable), and structure your reflection with an introduction, body, and conclusion.

Assignment 3: Psychological First Aid Module (25 points) Due Class 4

Students will complete a psychological first aid module online using the link provided: https://learn.nctsn.org/course/index.php?categoryid=11. Full points are awarded based on students providing evidence that the module has been completed (e.g., a snapshot of the certificate). *If a student does not pass the quizzes in the module, they will not receive credit for this assignment.*

Note: Because Assignments 2 and 3 take a significant amount of time, these modules will replace one live class session, to make up for this added instructional time.

Assignment 4: Institutional/Disaster Response Presentation- (Class 4)
Working in groups, students will select a real-life example of a crisis in a school or a natural disaster (e.g., Columbine school shooting or Hurricane Katrina) and give a 20-minute presentation to your colleagues. Presentation topics will be approved by the professor. Groups and events will be selected on the first day of class, and there will be no duplication. **There will be six groups total.** *See Discovery for resources. Presentations will include:

1. Provide a synopsis of the crisis or disaster scenario. Every group needs a unique type of crisis event. Event should have occurred at least 3 years ago and no more than 15 years ago.
2. Conduct an event/incident assessment using one of the models from chapter 12 or 13 of the Jackson-Cherry and Erford textbook.
3. Analyze how the crisis was managed using media/historical information and learning from the readings, considering what was done properly and areas for change.
4. Using learning from the readings and media coverage (if available) to highlight and discuss your understanding of the counselor role and responsibilities, as members of an interdisciplinary community outreach and emergency management response team. **Your discussion should be specific to this event using real life details and you must include details of other professionals essential to the counselor role/as part of the team.**
5. Long-term impact for survivors (may pull research from other events)
6. Provide strategies to support victims after the crisis event from a counseling perspective.
7. **Each participant will provide a 2-3 page personal reflection on the challenges they might experience working with this crisis and strategies, strengths, and characteristics for managing them. This reflection will be completed in class.**

Assignment 5: Self-Care Practice and Reflection
This assignment is designed to help you intentionally experience daily self-care and reflect on how consistent self-care affects your mood, stress level, awareness, and overall functioning. As future helping professionals, developing sustainable self-care habits is an essential professional skill. For **two consecutive weeks (14 days)**, you will try to engage in **one self-care activity each**

day. Self-care activities may include (but are not limited to):

- Meditation or mindfulness practice
- Walking or gentle exercise
- Yoga or stretching
- Creative activities (art, music, writing, crafts)
- Time in nature
- Journaling
- Prayer or spiritual practice
- Intentional rest or screen-free time
- **You will identify an activity in class 5.** Try to engage in the same activity every day, but if you are unable to maintain, you can switch to another activity that you may be more successful at completing.

Reflection

You will write a **handwritten reflection**. Reflection should be 2-3 pages. Reflections should include

- What self-care activity you did
- Approximately how long you engaged in the activity
- How you felt **before** the activity
- How you felt **after** the activity
- Any thoughts, emotions, or observations that stood out
- How could you apply this to your professional work as a counselor?

This assignment is graded on **completion and thoughtful engagement**, not on the type of self-care chosen or the outcome of the experience. There are no "right" or "wrong" reactions.

- Bring your **handwritten reflection journal to Class 7**.
- You may be asked to share general observations or insights from your experience in small or large group discussion.
- You will **not** be required to read your journal aloud or disclose personal details beyond your comfort level.

<u>Assignment 6: Faith Integration Reflection</u>

You will write a **2–3 page reflection paper (in-class)** exploring how faith and spirituality can inform and shape your approach to helping others cope with grief. This is a reflective and integrative assignment rather than a research paper. This will be completed in class 6.

D) Participation

A portion of the student's final grade will be based on their participation in class and group

discussions, in class exercises, individual and group presentations, and attendance. Full points will be rewarded to those students who attend all class sessions and actively participate in class activities.

E) Grading

Exams and presentations will be graded the same day. Papers will be graded within 2 weeks. If you have concerns about grading timing, please check with the professor, program coordinator, or program Chair.

The students course grade will be based upon her/his mastery of course terms, concept, and objections as demonstrated by classroom attendance, participation, presentations, and papers. Please be on time with all assignments, if late, there will be a deduction of grade points. Grading is conducted on the Discovery Grade Book page of the course. Students are expected to monitor their progress.

Grading Scale:

A	100-94%	C	76-74%
A-	93-90%	C-	73-70%
B+	89-87%	D+	69-67%
B	86-84%	D	66-64%
B-	83-80%	D-	63-60%
C+	79-77%	F	59% and below

F) Course Values

Item	***Point Value***
Nancy Case Study: Assessment and Intervention	100 points
Psychological First Aid Certificate	25 points
Group Presentation: Institutional/Disaster Response Reflection	50 points +25 points
Midterm Exam	75 points
Suicidal Assessment Training Reflection	25 points
Faith Integration Reflection	25 points
Self-Care Reflection	25 points
Class Attendance/Participation	40 points

Your participation is valuable!	***Total: 390 Points***

G) Lecture, Reading, and Assignment Outline
This guide serves as an outline for the course. Please refer to Discovery for detailed instructions for assignments, reading, and specific due dates for this course. Dates for specific lecture topics may change and material may need to be added or deleted. If any changes are made, they will be announced in class.

Week/Date	***Topics and Readings***	***Assignments***	***2024 CACREP Standards***
Class #1 Thursday, Jan 8	Reading- Jackson-Cherry & Erford, Ch. 1-3	Read the syllabus prior to the first class. Be ready to select topics for presentation	3.C.13 3.C.7 3.C.12
Class #2 Thursday, Feb 5	Crisis Intervention Skills and Suicide Risk Assessment Jackson-Cherry & Erford, Ch. 4, 6-7	**Suicide Intervention Videos and Reflection due before class**	3.E.19 3.E.20 3.G.13
Friday, Feb 13 **No live class meeting** Complete 5-hour Psychological 1st aid training and Suicidal Assessment Videos on your own time.	Psychological First Aid	Psychological First Aid Course Completed with Certificate by class 4	

Class #3 Thursday, Feb 26	IPV, Domestic Violence, and Sexual Violence Jackson-Cherry & Erford, Ch. 8-9	Midterm Exam (Jackson-Cherry & Erford, Ch. 1-4, 6)	3.C.7 3.C.12 3.G.14 3.G.16
Class #4 Thursday, March 5	Crisis in the community Jackson-Cherry & Erford, Ch. 12-13	**Institutional/Disaster Response Presentations (in-class reflection)** **Psychological first aid certificates due**	3.A.3
Class #5 Thursday, March 19	Child Sexual Abuse Military and first responders Jackson-Cherry & Erford, Ch. 10-11 Hunsinger, Chapters 1-2	**Nancy Case Study Due** (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=9-FBI91GBZY)	3.C.7 3.G.14 3.G.16

Class #6 Thursday, April 2	Focusing on the helper, integration of faith and culture Case study examples forgiveness, self-empathy Reading-Jackson-Cherry & Erford, Ch. 5 Hunsinger, Chapters 3-5	**Faith Integration Reflection (in-class)**	3.B.11 3.G.14 3.G.16
Class #7 Thursday, April 9	Restoration, and Ethical Considerations Reading-Hunsinger, Chapters 6-7 Jackson-Cherry & Erford, Ch. 14	**Self-Care Reflection Due**	3.B.11 3.G.14 3.G.16